

HEDGEHOGS, MOLES, AND RELATIVES

Four families in two orders have recently been grouped together in a new order Eulipotyphla, which means “truly fat and blind”. All of its members are small, long-snouted, primarily insectivorous mammals.

The four families in the Eulipotyphla are the Erinaceidae (hedgehogs and gymnures), Solenodontidae (solenodons), Talpidae (moles and desmans), and Soricidae (shrews). Most species of Erinaceidae have spines – only the gymnures have fur – and are predominantly terrestrial and nocturnal. The Solenodontidae is the smallest family but contains the two largest species, both of which live on Caribbean islands. The Talpidae is the most diverse of the four families, comprising 54 species

and including several types of burrowing mole and the sub-aquatic desmans. The Soricidae is the largest family, containing about 450 species, including one of the smallest of all mammals, the Etruscan shrew.

VENOMOUS SALIVA

Well adapted to their insectivorous way of life, the long, mobile, cartilaginous snout of shrews, moles, desmans, and solenodons contains numerous simple, sharp-pointed teeth, which they use to catch and kill prey, such as earthworms, other invertebrates, and small vertebrates. Some species produce venomous saliva, which in solenodons runs along a groove in one of their lower incisor teeth and helps to subdue larger prey before it is killed. By contrast, hedgehogs do not produce toxic saliva but some are immune to snake venom.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	EULIPOTYPHILA
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	530



Immunity to snake venom allows a hedgehog to take advantage of any snake it comes across as a potential food source.

HEDGEHOGS AND GYMNURES

With a long, sensitive snout and a short, hairy tail, members of the family Erinaceidae eat almost anything, from invertebrates and fruit to birds’ eggs and carrion. The hedgehogs, from Eurasia and Africa, are covered in sharp protective spines, while the southeast Asian gymnures have normal hair and look more like rats or opossums. Gymnures (also called moonrats) have especially well-developed scent glands that exude a strong garlic-like odour for marking territories.

WEST EUROPEAN HEDGEHOG

Erinaceus europaeus

Found throughout W. Europe, this species inhabits woodland, farmland, and gardens. In cooler areas, it hibernates in a nest of leaves and grass.

20–25 cm
8–10 in

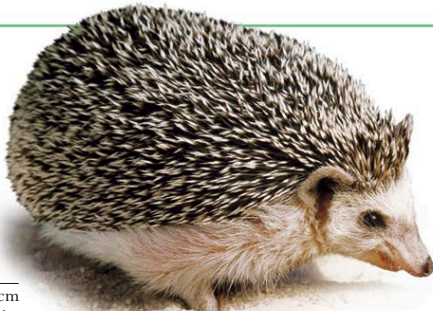


pale spines with darker bands



17–19 cm
6½–7½ in

SOUTHERN AFRICAN HEDGEHOG
Atelerix frontalis
Inhabiting grassland, scrub, and gardens in southern Africa, this species has a white band across its forehead, contrasting with its dark face.



20–27 cm
8–10½ in

NORTH AFRICAN HEDGEHOG
Atelerix algirus
Found in varied habitats in the Mediterranean region, this long-legged hedgehog with a pale face and underparts has a spineless “parting” on its crown.



14–26 cm
5½–10 in

AFRICAN PYGMY HEDGEHOG
Atelerix albiventris
Because the innermost digit of the hind feet is reduced or absent, this species is also known as the four-toed hedgehog.



13–24 cm
5–9½ in

DESERT HEDGEHOG
Paraechinus aethiopicus
This small African and Middle Eastern hedgehog is immune to the venom of snakes and scorpions, which form a large part of its diet.